The issue of attendance at Lodge meetings, and attempts to manage it, can be an emotive one. There are some Freemasons who take the view that *'Lodge meetings must always be a high priority and that members should manage their other commitments around them'*. There are others who accept that *'individuals can vary in their commitment to Freemasonry and that it is preferable to have in membership a good people who cannot attend every meeting than not to have them at all'*. In either case, almost every Freemason will occasionally miss a Lodge meeting.

However, we know that resignation is often preceded by periods of absence, relative to the individual's normal pattern of attendance. Therefore, a break in pattern and diminishing attendance is a warning sign of possible issues, whether they relate to reduced interest, dissatisfaction or a change of personal circumstances. It makes sense for Lodges to monitor individual attendance, and to make enquiries if absences vary or increase from their normal pattern.

*With the introduction of the **Hermes** system,* Lodge secretaries will be expected to update an attendance register for each meeting. *When a Lodge member misses two consecutive meetings, an automated notification will be sent to the **Lodge Almoner** in the first instance for action to be taken.*

Regular contact with non-attending members should occur in any case, no matter how many meetings are missed or whether apologies are registered. Quite often there are undisclosed reasons for non-attendance.

The following process has been found to be helpful and involves these Officers and members working closely together:

1. Using existing systems or Hermes, the Lodge Secretary maintains a record of attendance / absence at each meeting.
2. They send a copy of the record to the Lodge Mentor & Lodge Almoner shortly after each meeting.
3. The Lodge Almoner collates the data and monitors long term patterns and trends.
4. If a member is unexpectedly absent without submitting an apology, an agreed member of the Lodge Membership Team (eg, Lodge Almoner, Lodge Mentor or Personal Mentor) contacts them by phone.
5. The purpose of the telephone contact is to enquire about the member, their health and welfare, to offer assistance if appropriate and to express how the member was missed by the brethren. It is not to express disappointment in their absence or exert pressure. The member's needs motivate the call, not any inconvenience to the Lodge.
6. If a member has missed two consecutive meetings, whether with an apology or otherwise, an agreed person contacts them by phone within seven days of the second meeting.
7. The purpose of this contact is to identify any underlying cause for the absence and in particular any emerging disinterest or concerns held by the member. Compassion and support should underpin the discussion.
8. Relevant Lodge officers can then take appropriate action to address any personal needs for support, or any underlying causes, disinterest or concerns, before they escalate beyond any possibility of resolution.
9. If an impartial third party's involvement would assist (for example if the Lodge cannot manage the issue without losing the member to Freemasonry), the relevant Lodge Officer refers the matter to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District team responsible for retrieval.
10. The Lodge Almoner, Lodge Mentor and Personal Mentor keep an overview on individual cases and overall patterns and trends in attendance.
11. They report to the Lodge Membership Team and the Lodge Committee as appropriate so that both corrective and preventative actions can be taken before the Lodge's overall attendance levels diminish, ever mindful to respect any confidentiality and privacy issues.

12. When required, overall attendance levels are submitted to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Lodge.